guise of a yoga camp. He agreed to our demand which is why he was allowed to enter the city,' he claimed.

And yet, three days later, the government's worst fears came true. Ramdev stormed into his proposed indefinite hunger strike on the black money issue at the Ramlila Maidan, charging the Congress and the UPA government with being corrupt and unconcerned about bringing back black money. His supporters began gathering in large numbers. A desperate government reiterated its appeal to him to call off the fast, with Sibal even making public a letter of Ramdev's aide assuring that the fast would be called off if a legislation was enacted on black money. An angry Ramdev accused the government of 'betrayal'. A battle of wits was being played out in the glare of television—a tough-talking, charismatic yoga guru with a vast following of common, devout folk, a god-man with nothing to lose, versus a mighty Union government whose credibility was on the line.

At midnight on a hot June night, as the devotees slept in crowded ranks at Ramlila Maidan, the Delhi police swooped down on the protestors, firing tear-gas shells and resorting to a lathi charge, forcing people out even as they were half asleep. Ramdev, who escaped disguised as a woman, was eventually detained and forced to leave the city. A few of his supporters were injured in the clashes with the police. One of them, Rajbala, was grievously hurt; she died in hospital weeks later. Ramdev had been dramatically transformed from controversial yoga guru into a heroic figure. The Government of India had been shown up as effete and insensitive. A sleeping congregation is not an unlawful assembly, the Supreme Court thundered a year later.

In a media interaction just ahead of the Lok Sabha results in 2014, then home minister P. Chidambaram said Ramdev had played a political game. 'He was not conducting a yoga camp. He was holding a political show. I think the way it was handled was right, except for that last misstep,' he argued. He even challenged those who called the yoga guru a 'baba'. 'He is no baba . . . he is no saint, just call him Mr Ramdev.'

And yet, in the summer of 2011, this same 'Mr Ramdev' had forced the government into an almost unprecedented panic mode. Intelligence sources